

Viva Dental Prep — NBDHE Board Exam Strategy & Vocabulary Guide

For Spanish-Speaking Dental Hygiene Students (Enseñando a Estudiantes Hispanohablantes)

Chapters 9 & 10: Microbiology, Immunology & Infection Control

■ INTRODUCTION / INTRODUCCIÓN

For native Spanish speakers preparing for the NBDHE (National Board Dental Hygiene Examination), success requires both **dental hygiene knowledge** and **mastery of English board exam test-taking syntax**. NBDHE questions use specific "trigger words," negative phrasing, priority qualifiers, and clinical jargon that can easily confuse students who translate word-for-word.

This guide breaks down key board question strategies, critical vocabulary from Chapters 9 & 10, common grammatical traps, and false cognates.

■ SECTION 1: CRITICAL BOARD QUESTION MODIFIERS & TRIGGER WORDS

(Palabras Clave Trampa y Descriptores de Preguntas)

Board questions frequently use modifier words that change the entire meaning of the question stem. Look out for these four main categories:

1. Negative Stems & Eliminators (Preguntas Negativas o de Exclusión)

When you see these words, 3 options are CORRECT statements, and 1 option is FALSE. Your goal is to find the FALSE statement!

- **EXCEPT** (*Excepto / Con excepción de*):
 - *Strategy*: Read each option as True or False. Mark "T" for true options and "F" for false options. The single "F" option is your correct answer!
 - *Example*: "All of the following are signs of inflammation EXCEPT one." → Find the option that is NOT a cardinal sign of inflammation (**Bleeding**).
 - **NOT** (*NO / No es*):
 - *Strategy*: Highlights an item that does not belong.
 - *Example*: "Which strain of Hepatitis is NOT bloodborne?" → **Hepatitis A** (fecal-oral).
 - **LEAST likely** (*Lo menos probable*):
 - *Strategy*: Asks for the option with the lowest probability or weakest clinical connection.
 - **FALSE / INCORRECT** (*Falso / Incorrecto*):
 - *Strategy*: Identify the inaccurate statement among true statements.
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2. Priority & Sequential Modifiers (Orden, Prioridad y Secuencia Clínica)

Board exams test what you must do **FIRST** for safety or what is **MOST** clinically important.

- **FIRST / INITIAL action** (*Primera acción / Paso inicial*):
 - *Strategy*: Asks for the immediate emergency or infection control protocol.

- **Example:** "What is the **FIRST** action following a sharps injury?" → **Wash with soap and water** (Reporting to supervisor is second).
- **MOST likely** (*Lo más probable / Diagnóstico principal*):
 - **Strategy:** Pick the primary etiologic pathogen or primary diagnosis, not rare exceptions.
 - **Example:** "Which organism is **MOST likely** found in early supragingival plaque?" → **Gram-positive cocci and rods**.
- **PRIMARY / PRINCIPAL** (*Principal / Dominante*):
 - **Strategy:** Select the main cause or responder.
 - **Example:** "Which immune cell is the **PRIMARY** first responder?" → **PMNs (Neutrophils)**.
- **BEST** (*El mejor / La opción óptima*):
 - **Strategy:** Multiple options may be good, but **ONE** represents the gold standard of care.
- **NEXT step** (*Siguiente paso*):
 - **Strategy:** Follow strict clinical workflow sequence.

3. Absolute & Distractor Terms (Palabras Extremas y Distractores)

- **ALL of the above** (*Todas las anteriores*):
 - **Strategy:** Only correct if EVERY single option is 100% true. If even one option is false, eliminate "All of the above."
- **NONE of the above** (*Ninguna de las anteriores*):
 - **Strategy:** Asks if all listed choices are incorrect.
- **ALWAYS / NEVER** (*Siempre / Nunca*):
 - **Strategy:** **CAUTION!** In dentistry and biology, absolute terms like "always" or "never" are almost always FALSE options because biological systems have exceptions.

■ SECTION 2: CHAPTER 9 ESSENTIAL VOCABULARY

(Microbiology & Immunology / Microbiología e Inmunología)

English Term	Spanish Translation	Simple Clinical Definition	Board Question Context / Example
Prokaryote	Procariota	Single-celled organism without a membrane-bound nucleus (e.g. Bacteria).	"Eubacteria and Archeobacteria are prokaryotic organisms."
Eukaryote	Eucariota	Cell containing a true membrane-bound nucleus & organelles (e.g. Fungi, Human cells).	"Fungi are eukaryotic, possessing a nuclear membrane."
Carrier	Portador (Asintomático)	An individual who harbors a pathogen and can transmit it without showing symptoms.	"A carrier has recovered from illness but can still transmit the infection."
Biofilm	Biofilm / Película biológica	Dense, structured community of microorganisms embedded in a self-produced matrix on enamel/surfaces.	"Flushing DUWLs removes loose bacteria but does NOT eliminate biofilm."
Planktonic	Plactónico (Flotante)	Free-floating single bacteria in liquid (not attached to a biofilm).	"Flushing water lines for 2 minutes removes planktonic bacteria."
Endospore	Endospora / Espora bacteriana	Highly resistant, dormant structure formed by certain bacteria (e.g. <i>Bacillus</i> , <i>Clostridium</i>) to survive extreme heat/chemicals.	"Intermediate disinfectants cannot destroy bacterial endospores."

Opportunistic	Oportunista	Infection caused by pathogens that take advantage of a weakened immune system.	<i>"Kaposi sarcoma and oral candidiasis are opportunistic HIV infections."</i>
Humoral Immunity	Inmunidad Humoral	B-lymphocyte antibody-mediated immunity circulating in body fluids.	<i>"Humoral immunity relies on B-cells producing specific immunoglobulins."</i>
Cell-Mediated	Inmunidad Celular	T-lymphocyte mediated immune response targeting infected cells directly.	<i>"Cell-mediated immunity is driven by T-lymphocytes and cytokines."</i>
PMNs (Neutrophils)	Polimorfonucleares (PMN)	The first white blood cells (phagocytes) to arrive at a site of acute inflammation.	<i>"PMNs are the first line of cellular defense in acute infection."</i>
Passive Immunity	Inmunidad Pasiva	Temporary immunity acquired by receiving preformed antibodies (e.g., mother to fetus).	<i>"Maternal IgG transferred across the placenta provides passive immunity."</i>
Active Immunity	Inmunidad Activa	Long-lasting immunity produced by the body's own immune response to antigen or vaccine.	<i>"Natural active immunity develops after recovering from a disease."</i>
Pathognomonic	Patognomónico	A characteristic sign or symptom specifically diagnostic for a particular disease.	<i>"Strawberry tongue is pathognomonic for Scarlet Fever."</i>
Demineralization	Desmineralización	Loss of mineral (calcium/phosphate) from tooth structure when pH drops below critical levels.	<i>"Enamel demineralization occurs at pH 4.5–5.5; root surface at pH 6.0–6.7."</i>

■ SECTION 3: CHAPTER 10 ESSENTIAL VOCABULARY

(Infection Control & Safety / Control de Infecciones)

English Term	Spanish Translation	Simple Clinical Definition	Board Question Context / Example
Spaulding Classification	Clasificación de Spaulding	System categorizing medical/dental items into Critical, Semicritical, and Noncritical.	<i>"Instruments penetrating bone are critical items requiring sterilization."</i>
Critical Item	Ítem Crítico	Penetrates soft tissue or bone (e.g. Curette, Scaler, Forceps). Requires heat sterilization.	<i>"Dental hygiene curettes are critical items."</i>
Semicritical Item	Ítem Semicrítico	Touches mucous membranes or nonintact skin without penetrating (e.g. Mirror, Sensor).	<i>"Mouth mirrors touch mucous membranes and are semicritical."</i>
Noncritical Item	Ítem No Crítico	Touches intact skin only (e.g. BP cuff, X-ray cone). Requires low/intermediate disinfection.	<i>"Blood pressure cuffs touch intact skin and are noncritical."</i>
Donning	Colocación (de EPP)	The process of putting on Personal Protective Equipment in proper sequence.	<i>"Proper donning sequence: Gown → Mask & Eyewear → Hand Hygiene → Gloves."</i>
Doffing	Retiro (de EPP)	The process of taking off Personal Protective Equipment safely.	<i>"Remove gloves first during doffing to prevent cross-contamination."</i>

Engineering Controls	Controles de Ingeniería	Physical safety devices that isolate or eliminate hazards from workers (e.g. Sharps box, Recapper).	<i>"A puncture-resistant sharps container is an engineering control device."</i>
Work Practice Controls	Controles de Práctica	Safe work behavior/procedures that reduce risk of exposure (e.g. One-handed scoop technique).	<i>"The one-handed scoop technique is a work practice control behavior."</i>
Percutaneous	Percutáneo (Pinchazo/Corte)	Exposure occurring through the skin via needle-stick or sharp instrument cut.	<i>"Percutaneous exposure requires immediate washing with soap and water."</i>
OPIM	OPIM (Materiales Infecciosos)	Other Potentially Infectious Materials (saliva, gingival fluid, semen, body fluids).	<i>"Standard Precautions treat blood and all OPIM as infectious."</i>
Tuberculocidal	Tuberculicida	Chemical disinfectant capable of inactivating <i>Mycobacterium tuberculosis</i> (Intermediate level).	<i>"Intermediate-level disinfectants used on contaminated surfaces must be tuberculocidal."</i>
Spore Testing	Prueba de Esporas	Biological monitoring using resistant spores to verify sterilizer efficacy (At least weekly).	<i>"Biological monitoring (spore testing) must occur at least weekly."</i>
Class V Integrator	Integrador Clase V	Chemical indicator placed inside instrument cassettes reacting to time, temp & steam.	<i>"Class V chemical integrators monitor all critical parameters inside a cassette."</i>
Infection Control Coordinator	Coordinador de Infecciones	Designated office member responsible for managing policies, training, and CDC updates.	<i>"The CDC recommends appointing an Infection Control Coordinator (ICC)."</i>

SECTION 4: ENGLISH GRAMMAR & SYNTAX PITFALLS FOR SPANISH SPEAKERS

(Trampas de Gramática y Falsos Amigos)

1. False Cognates (Falsos Amigos que Confunden)

- **Severe** ≠ *Severo* (does NOT mean "severo"):
- In English board questions, *severe* means **grave / intenso** (e.g., *severe periodontitis* = periodontitis grave). In Spanish, "severo" often means strict or harsh.
- **Sanitize** ≠ *Sanitizar* (does NOT mean "sanitizar"):
- In English infection control, *sanitize* means reducing bacteria to safe public health levels (low level). It does **NOT** mean sterilize (*esterilizar*) or disinfect (*desinfectar*).
- **Preserve** ≠ *Preservar* (does NOT mean "preservar"):
- In board context, *preserve* means maintaining tissue structure or retaining teeth (*preserve alveolar bone*).
- **Resistant** ≠ *Resistente* (does NOT mean "resistente"):
- Be careful: *resistant host* means an immune host (*huésped inmune*), whereas a *susceptible host* is vulnerable to infection.

2. Prepositions & Temporal Connectors (Conectores Temporales y Lógicos)

- **Prior to** = *Antes de* ("Prior to gloving, perform hand hygiene.")
- **Subsequent to** = *Después de / Posterior a* ("Subsequent to exposure, seek medical PEP within 2 hours.")
- **As opposed to** = *A diferencia de / En contraste con* ("Prokaryotes lack a nucleus as opposed to eukaryotes.")

- **Provided that** = Siempre y cuando / Con la condición de que ("Instruments may be stored provided that the pouch remains sealed.")

3. Strategy for Double Negatives in Board Questions

- In Spanish, double negatives are common and grammatically correct ("No hay nada").
- In English board questions, double negatives cancel each other out and create a POSITIVE statement!
- **Rule:**
 - **NOT un-acceptable** = Acceptable
 - **NOT in-effective** = Effective
 - **NOT non-critical** = Critical or Semicritical

■ SECTION 5: STEP-BY-STEP BOARD QUESTION DISSECTION EXAMPLES

(Ejemplos Prácticos de Descomposición de Preguntas)

Example 1: Handling **EXCEPT** (Chapter 10, Q10)

Question Stem: "All of the following are examples of work practice controls **EXCEPT** one. Which is the **EXCEPTION**?"

* Options:

- * A. Self-sheathing needles
- * B. One-handed scoop technique for recapping
- * C. Maintaining a 14–18 inch working distance
- * D. Fulcruming 1–4 teeth away

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Step-by-Step Spanish Student Dissection:

1. Identify the trigger word: **EXCEPT**. You are looking for the item that is **NOT** a work practice control (behavior).
2. Test option A: Self-sheathing needle = Physical device → **Engineering control** (NOT a work practice behavior!).
3. Test options B, C, D: All are human actions/behaviors → Work practice controls.
4. **Correct Answer: A. Self-sheathing needles.**

Example 2: Handling **FIRST action** (Chapter 10, Q24)

Question Stem: "What is the **FIRST** action that should be taken when a percutaneous (sharps injury) happens?"

* Options:

- * A. Wash the area with soap and water
- * B. Yell for help
- * C. Report the injury to supervisor
- * D. Get an HIV test

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Step-by-Step Spanish Student Dissection:

1. Identify the trigger word: **FIRST action**. You need the immediate initial clinical step.
2. Option C (reporting) and Option D (HIV test) are correct protocol steps, but they happen **AFTER** immediate wound care.
3. Option A is the immediate first physical step to reduce pathogen load at the puncture site.
4. **Correct Answer: A. Wash the area with soap and water.**

Viva Dental Prep — Board Review Study Materials